

Reassessing Recent Inequality Trends in Chile

Income, Wealth, and Survey Disagreement, 2007–2024

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Abstract

Since Chile's return to democracy, declining economic inequality has become a prominent and consequential account of the country's development. Yet the empirical foundation of that account is narrower than the multiplicity of available estimates might suggest. Many prominent international income series ultimately derive from a single underlying source, the National Socioeconomic Characterization Survey (CASEN). Their agreement therefore demonstrates robustness across alternative constructions of CASEN income, but does not constitute independent replication across household surveys. Moreover, CASEN lacks the comprehensive balance-sheet data needed to determine whether wealth inequality, which carries different consequences for living standards, economic security, opportunity, and political power, has followed the same trend documented in income inequality. This paper asks how far the influential CASEN-based narrative of income compression travels across survey systems and household resources. It examines whether the more recent CASEN income path is reproduced in independently collected microdata from the Central Bank's Household Financial Survey (EFH) and whether income and non-pension net-wealth inequality move in the same direction within EFH. I harmonize all six national EFH waves from 2007 through 2024 and construct the closest feasible comparison with urban CASEN households. After an exceptional fall in 2021 and a rebound by 2024, the EFH income Gini ends only 0.030 below its 2007 value, a net change statistically indistinguishable from zero. Over the closest common-concept period, 2017–2024, EFH's income Gini edges up from 0.519 to 0.523, whereas CASEN's falls from 0.482 to 0.464, and top-10 and bottom-50 income shares produce the same directional contrast. The resulting EFH–CASEN Gini gap widens, although the difference between the two estimated changes is not statistically significant. As for wealth within EFH, the only statistically significant adjacent change in net-wealth inequality occurs from 2021 to 2024, when the Gini excluding mandatory pension entitlements rises from 0.698 to 0.766, the top-10 share increases, and the bottom-50 share falls. Thus, the continued post-2017 income compression recorded by CASEN is absent from EFH's point estimates, while EFH records substantial increases in income and non-pension net-wealth inequality between its final two waves. Whether measured inequality continued to fall in Chile through 2024 therefore depends on both the survey system and the household resource under study.

Keywords: Chile; income inequality; wealth inequality; household finance survey; public transfers; survey disagreement

JEL classification: C81; D31; E01

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I thank the participants of my research seminar, especially Eric Monnet and Jérôme Bourdieu, for their helpful suggestions as well as Xavier Jara-Tamayo for accepting to act as referee. This thesis would not have been possible without the patient support and guidance provided by my supervisor, Facundo Alvaredo. All errors are my own.

1 Introduction

Chile appeared to be moving against one of the defining distributional concerns of the early twenty-first century. While rising income and wealth concentration returned to the center of economic research, household-survey estimates reported across prominent international databases placed Chile’s income Gini near the Latin American peak around 1990 and roughly ten points lower by the middle of the 2010s (Alvaredo et al., 2025). The *Encuesta de Caracterización Socioeconómica Nacional* (CASEN; National Socioeconomic Characterization Survey), the country’s principal survey for poverty and income distribution, supplies the most continuous evidence behind that account. Whether this measured income compression continued beyond the mid-2010s is less clear, as is whether wealth inequality followed the same path.

Answering both questions credibly requires care. Both the level and movement of measured inequality depend on what constitutes household resources, the units over which they are distributed, and the adjustments applied to the microdata. A household total, household income per capita distributed among persons, equivalized disposable income, and equal-split national income assign different resources to different units. Nonresponse corrections, imputed rent, upper-tail treatment, and population coverage introduce further variation. Studies of secondary inequality databases and Latin American microdata show that these choices can change both country rankings and comparisons over time (Atkinson and Brandolini, 2001; Székely and Hilgert, 2007; Alvaredo et al., 2025). Incomplete coverage at the top creates another source of uncertainty (Blanchet et al., 2022). The underlying microdata are therefore as important as the published series. For Chile, the Socio-Economic Database for Latin America and the Caribbean (SEDLAC), the Economic Commission for Latin America and the Caribbean (ECLAC), and the World Bank’s Poverty and Inequality Platform (PIP) ultimately process CASEN observations. The Luxembourg Income Study (LIS) and the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) Income Distribution Database do so as well. Their agreement shows that the historical decline survives several treatments of CASEN. Yet that agreement leaves the central cross-survey test unanswered: does that decline also appear in independently collected household-survey microdata?

The *Encuesta Financiera de Hogares* (EFH; Household Financial Survey), produced by the Central Bank of Chile (Banco Central de Chile), provides an important counterpoint: it is collected independently of CASEN and measures both household income and household balance

sheets. Designed around household finances, EFH uses a wealth-related oversampling frame and multiple imputation for missing financial items. EFH’s national waves represent urban households, whereas CASEN also covers rural households. The closest comparison therefore restricts CASEN to its urban sample and aligns survey year, household unit, and the treatment of imputed rent. EFH’s income aggregate still differs from CASEN’s official construct, and EFH remains a separate survey system rather than another transformation of CASEN. This paper asks how far the influential CASEN-based narrative of income compression travels across survey systems and household resources. It examines whether the more recent CASEN income path is reproduced in independently collected microdata from EFH and whether income and non-pension net-wealth inequality move in the same direction within EFH.

To answer these questions, I estimate the income path supported by each source under an explicit estimand, compare income with net wealth within EFH, and use income composition and the EFH survivor sample to examine parts of the post-2017 survey disagreement. Judging which survey is closest to an unobserved true distribution lies outside the design, as does attributing the income and wealth movements to a common mechanism.

Three findings organize the answer. First, EFH’s income Gini falls modestly through 2017, drops exceptionally in 2021, and returns to approximately its 2017 level in 2024. The corresponding household-income Ginis are 0.519, 0.439, and 0.523. The 2024 estimate is 0.030 below its 2007 value, and this net change is not statistically distinguishable from zero. Second, CASEN’s closest household-income Gini moves from 0.482 in 2017 to 0.464 in 2024, while the EFH-minus-CASEN gap widens from 0.037 to 0.059. The estimated difference between the two changes is not statistically significant, so the contrast concerns their point-estimate paths rather than a statistically resolved difference in trends. Bottom-half and top-decile income shares tell the same directional story: CASEN records compression at both tails, while EFH records little endpoint movement. Third, EFH’s signed non-pension wealth Gini fluctuates across the first five waves without a statistically significant adjacent change. It then rises between 2021 and 2024, from 0.698 to 0.766, its highest point estimate in the six-wave series. Thus both EFH Ginis increased between the final two waves, although income and wealth measure different resources and need not share a mechanism. Income and wealth ranks are positively but imperfectly associated within EFH households, so the two series capture related rather than duplicate dimensions of economic position.

Figure 1 places the EFH income and wealth paths side by side. The two panels make the

cross-resource comparison visible at the outset: the exceptional 2021 income trough reverses by 2024, while wealth inequality rises between the final two waves.

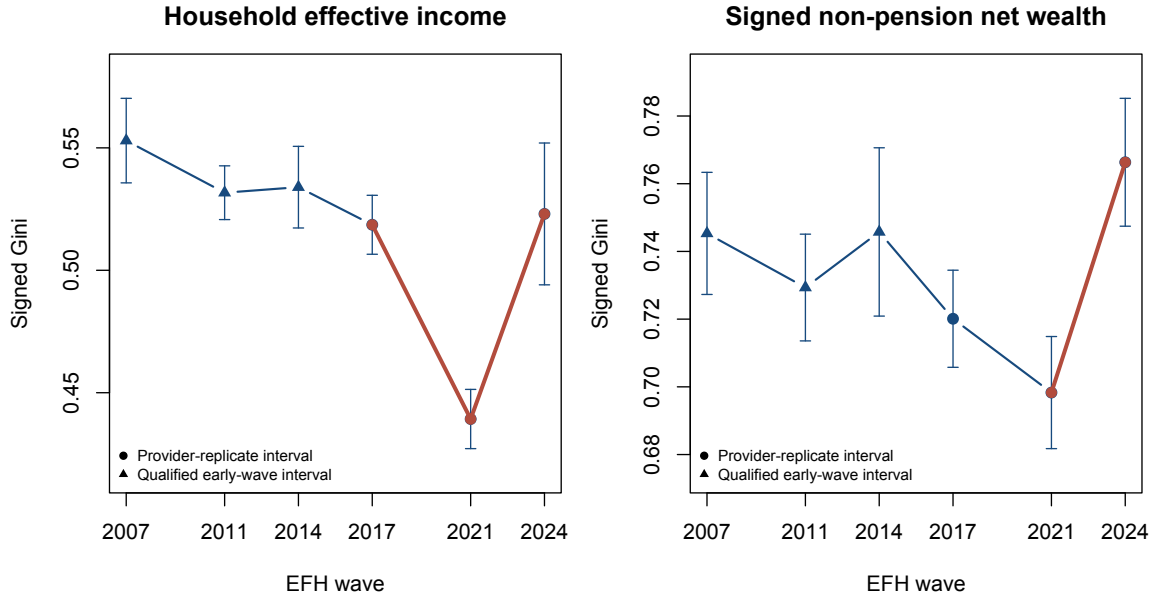


Figure 1: EFH income and signed-wealth inequality

Two diagnostics give the income reversal more context. Public transfers' share of measured EFH effective income rises from 0.8 percent in 2017 to 13.5 percent in 2021 and recedes to 3.1 percent in 2024. Exact component accounting locates the rest of the swing in labor and other autonomous income. Among the 1,801 households reinterviewed in 2024, the reversal persists under both common-2024 and common-2021 weighting systems. This makes sample refresh an insufficient explanation, but it does not turn the survivor exercise into a representative longitudinal estimate. Wealth also moves toward greater concentration among these same households under both weighting systems, although that change is attenuated and its conservative intervals include zero.

To my knowledge, this paper provides the first joint account of income and released non-pension net-wealth inequality across all six national EFH waves, including the 2024 endpoint. EFH thereby provides both a separate survey-system check on the recent income path and a view of whether income and wealth inequality changed in the same direction. Related work integrates pensions, macro balance sheets, and upper-tail corrections through 2021 (Castro Nofal et al., 2026). That complementary construction addresses a broader wealth concept, whereas the present comparison retains the released EFH estimand and examines its income series alongside CASEN. The paper carries multiple-imputation and survey-design uncertainty through its estimates, uses

component accounts to locate the observed income and wealth changes, and uses the survivor domain to test whether the final-wave movements depend entirely on sample refresh. These diagnostics characterize the results without identifying their causes.

The remainder of the paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 establishes the Chilean decline, audits its source lineage, and explains what EFH adds. Section 3 defines the data, estimands, and inference. Section 4 reports EFH income and wealth trends. Section 5 characterizes the post-2017 disagreement through the closest-concept comparison, income components, and the survivor domain. Section 6 closes by asking how far the lower 2024 inequality endpoint recorded in CASEN can be generalized across survey systems and household resources, and what the answer means for accounts of declining inequality in Chile.

2 Chile’s inequality decline and its evidentiary lineage

2.1 The established decline and the measurement problem

CASEN supplies Chile’s principal repeated record of household income, poverty, and monetary subsidies. Its continuity helps explain why declining inequality became the default account of the first two decades of this century. Chilean studies describe an increase during the 1990s followed by a marked fall between 2000 and 2011, while regional harmonizations carry the decline into the middle of the 2010s (Parro and Reyes, 2017; Alvaredo et al., 2025). In their review of Latin American inequality, Alvaredo et al. (2025) place Chile’s Gini about ten points below its value around 1990 and identify 2015 as the trough in all four harmonized Chilean series. They describe the subsequent movement in Chile as a relatively mild increase, while emphasizing that this third regional episode is mixed and may still be too recent to characterize.

The economic literature has placed labor earnings at the center of that decline. For 2000–2011, decompositions emphasize the expansion of tertiary education, a falling wage premium for skills, and the resulting compression of labor income; more progressive public transfers also contributed, but on a smaller scale than labor income in the Chilean account (Parro and Reyes, 2017). Recent CASEN work extends the study of education and labor-income dispersion through 2024, while documenting weaker real earnings for tertiary graduates after 2015 (Rodriguez Tapia, 2026). These explanations concern changes measured in CASEN. They motivate the component analysis below while leaving open whether the same movements appear in a survey built for household finances.

Figure 4 in [Alvaredo et al. \(2025\)](#) motivates the lineage audit developed here. It places SEDLAC, ECLAC’s newer survey-only series, PovcalNet/PIP, and LIS inside a preferred band of four microdata-based household-survey series. Across the period beginning around 1990, those lines, supplemented by more fragmented published series, trace a clear medium-run decline in Chile and reach their reported troughs in 2015. The four series differ in level but share a broadly comparable unit: household per-capita income distributed among persons. They apply different harmonization and processing rules to CASEN, so their agreement demonstrates robustness across treatments of one survey rather than replication in four independent household samples.

Figure 2 makes that historical benchmark visible using one frozen CASEN-derived PIP series. PIP applies its own welfare construction and population conventions, so the plot documents the prevailing long-run account without adding an independent survey or a direct level comparison with EFH.

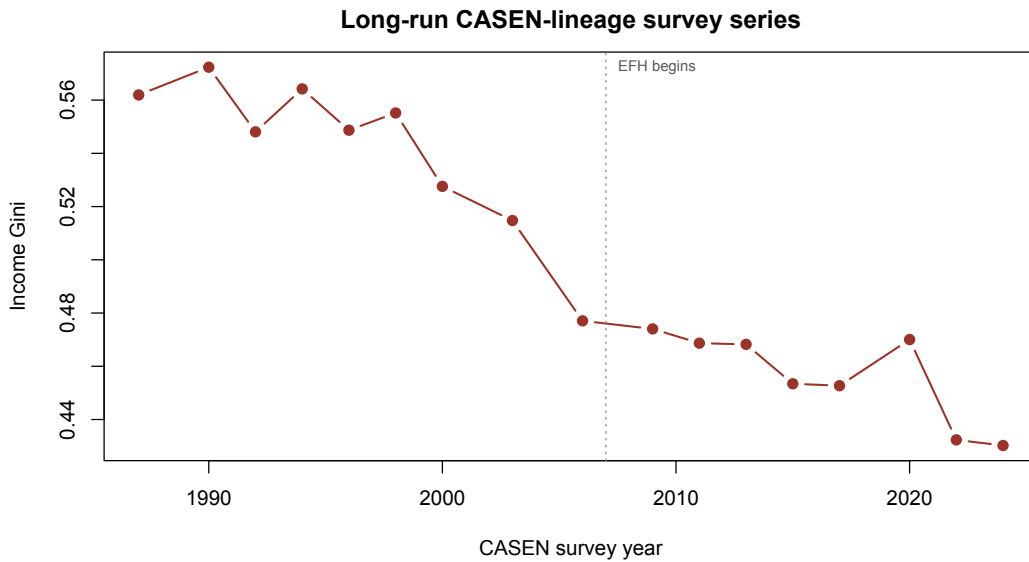


Figure 2: The historical decline in a CASEN-lineage income-Gini series

Within PIP’s frozen 2006–2024 comparable spell, the Gini falls from 0.477 to 0.430. That 0.047 decline is larger than the 0.030 endpoint decline in the EFH household Gini from 2007 to 2024, but the person-weighted PIP welfare concept supports a broad comparison of direction rather than a direct comparison of levels.

Evidence outside that survey band complicates the size and timing of the decline. Tax-based studies show that business income, retained earnings, and upper-tail treatment materially affect measured concentration ([Fairfield and Jorratt De Luis, 2016](#); [Flores et al., 2020](#)). Adjusting CASEN with national accounts and administrative records can also flatten the 2003–2017 trend,

depending on the income concept and correction used (Larrañaga et al., 2022; Ministerio de Desarrollo Social y Familia, 2026). Distributional national accounts widen the resource boundary further by allocating income absent from surveys (Piketty et al., 2018; Alvaredo et al., 2022). These results qualify the survey narrative rather than supply another independently sampled household-income path.

2.2 One survey lineage, several published series

Source lineage records the upstream microdata as well as the downstream publisher. A recent global audit reaches a closely related conclusion: apparent plurality across inequality databases partly reflects database proliferation and overlapping genealogies rather than independent measurement (Ceriani and Verme, 2026). That study provides useful corroboration at a different scale. The audit here traces prominent Chilean observations back to their household surveys and separates shared microdata from shared methodology. SEDLAC constructs harmonized current household income and commonly reports household per-capita income distributed among persons; its Chilean input is CASEN (CEDLAS and World Bank, 2025). World Bank PIP draws on SEDLAC for Latin America and applies additional treatment, so the two series need not be numerically identical (World Bank, 2023). ECLAC’s newer series is computed from its Household Survey Data Bank (BADEHOG), whose Chilean files are CASEN (Economic Commission for Latin America and the Caribbean, 2025). LIS’s Chilean income files are harmonizations of CASEN (LIS Cross-National Data Center, 2018). OECD’s Income Distribution Database also lists CASEN as the Chilean source, but distributes equivalized disposable cash income among persons and excludes imputed rent (OECD, 2026).

WIID plays a different role. It is a secondary database and companion-series producer that gathers and standardizes estimates from national statistics, SEDLAC, LIS, OECD, and other providers (UNU-WIDER, 2025). The Standardized World Income Inequality Database (SWIID) similarly uses a model to standardize observations toward a common LIS-based concept (Solt, 2020). Both can broaden historical coverage or support cross-country analysis, but neither turns a published Chilean estimate into a new household survey. Conversely, WID combines survey, administrative, fiscal, and national-accounts information, and UBS or Credit Suisse combines surveys, balance sheets, and models to estimate adult wealth. These constructions bring distinct information and methods to the question, though their estimands lie farther from the household-level EFH measure. The *World Inequality Report 2026*, for example, describes

Chilean inequality as having declined noticeably since 2014, but its 2024 series distributes pre-tax national income among individuals rather than reproducing a household-survey Gini ([World Inequality Lab, 2026](#)).

By contrast, the principal harmonized international household-wealth series available for Chile through the OECD Wealth Distribution Database and the Luxembourg Wealth Study trace back to EFH. OECD refers to EFH as the “Survey of Household Finances,” while the Luxembourg Wealth Study identifies its Chilean files as EFH-based ([OECD, 2025b](#); [LIS Cross-National Data Center, 2025](#)). These databases give EFH-based wealth evidence international reach and comparability, but, as with CASEN-based income series, their common reliance on one survey means that apparent agreement does not constitute independent reproduction of Chile’s wealth trend.

Chile also has independently collected survey evidence outside the CASEN and EFH lineages. The National Statistics Institute’s Supplementary Survey of Income (ESI) now measures employed persons’ labor income rather than total household resources, while the University of Chile’s Employment and Unemployment Survey represents Greater Santiago ([Instituto Nacional de Estadísticas, 2022](#); [Sanhueza and Mayer, 2011](#)). The Household Budget Survey (EPF) independently measures income and expenditure in regional capitals and has supported studies of consumption inequality and tax and price incidence, but its periodicity, coverage, and income definitions do not supply a comparable endpoint through 2024 ([Madeira, 2023](#); [World Bank, 2015](#); [OECD, 2025a](#); [Instituto Nacional de Estadísticas, 2022](#)). The Encuesta de Protección Social (EPS; Social Protection Survey) has collected wealth information since 2004, but its person weights, mixed ownership units, incomplete balance-sheet coverage, and missing-value-sensitive screening estimates prevent treating it as a replication of EFH household net wealth ([Subsecretaría de Previsión Social, 2017, 2025](#)).¹ These surveys provide valuable evidence for narrower populations or resources, but none supplies the national-urban household-income or household-net-wealth path required for the present comparison. I therefore use EFH as the main survey counterpoint to CASEN while retaining EPF and EPS in the lineage audit.

Figure 3 summarizes the sources audited in this paper. Arrows indicate documented upstream inheritance, not identical methods or published numbers. Independence and comparability are separate dimensions: a series may be closely comparable but derivative, or independently constructed while estimating a different population and resource.

¹The screening code and decision record are available [online](#).

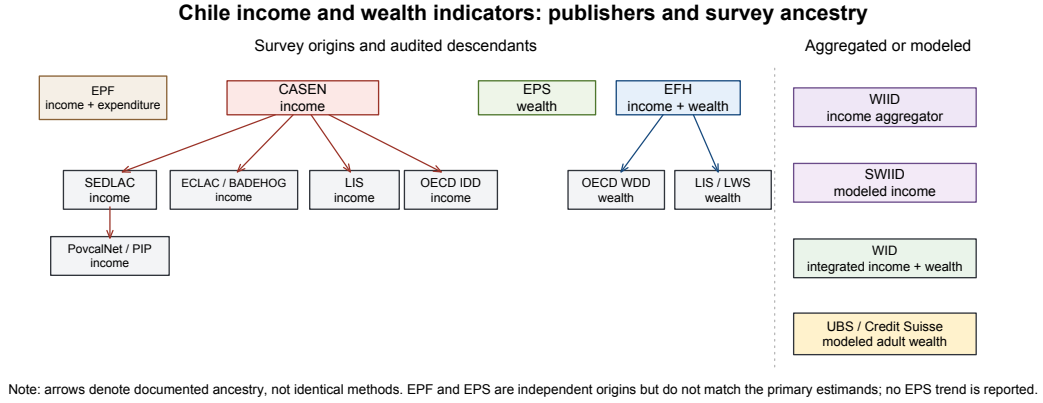


Figure 3: Source lineage of the series audited in this paper

Agreement across the CASEN family therefore supports a precise conclusion: Chile’s historical decline is robust to several treatments of CASEN. Among the sources audited here, however, a comparable national household-total-income series built from independent microdata has not reproduced the full path. EFH begins only in 2007, so it cannot adjudicate the early decline, but it can test how confidently the more recent direction travels across survey systems. The audit accordingly counts transformations and independent measurements separately, without discounting the information contained in either.

2.3 What EFH adds

EFH is a different instrument. It is designed around household finances and balance sheets, uses oversampling tied to a wealth proxy, and releases multiple imputations for item nonresponse. Its unit is the household and its national waves represent urban households. The effective-income measure used here adds labor income, pensions, public subsidies, and other income at the household level while excluding imputed owner rent. CASEN’s official monetary-income measure instead aggregates corrected person-level autonomous income and cash subsidies under the ministry’s procedures. The closest comparison removes imputed rent from both, but the questionnaires and correction systems remain different. Comparing their Gini levels as if the income concepts were identical would therefore overstate precision. These same differences make EFH useful as an independent survey check rather than another treatment of CASEN.

EFH has been used primarily to study debt, financial fragility, and wealth. Studies using the 2007, 2011–12, or 2014 cross sections document the distribution of assets and liabilities and show that income is related only imperfectly to a household’s wealth rank (Bauducco et al., 2019; Martínez and Uribe, 2017, 2018; Banco Central de Chile, 2007–2024). Cross-country work also places the 2017 EFH wealth distribution in a harmonized comparison with three other Latin American surveys (Gandelman and Lluberá, 2024). More recent work constructs a micro–macro wealth distribution through 2021 by adding pension entitlements, national balance sheets, and upper-tail corrections (Castro Nofal et al., 2026). That study provides the most comprehensive account of modern Chilean wealth dynamics, but it does not trace EFH income inequality across the six national waves or compare that path with CASEN.

The present paper deliberately retains the narrower released survey concepts. Against this literature, it traces income inequality and released non-pension net-wealth inequality jointly across all six national EFH waves, including the 2024 endpoint, and places the EFH income path beside CASEN. This scope makes it possible to compare the recent direction of income and wealth within one survey while using EFH income as an independent counterpoint to CASEN, without claiming a comprehensive measure of household wealth.

2.4 The unsettled endpoint and pandemic comparability

The latest observation changes how the recent record is read. A series that is lower in 2024 than in 2017 supports continued compression. A series that falls exceptionally in a pandemic round and then returns to its earlier level supports temporary compression. Both descriptions can fit parts of Chile’s public record, but they support different conclusions about the direction through 2024.

The 2021 EFH and 2020 CASEN are also unusual observations. EFH fieldwork was largely remote during emergency transfers and labor-market disruption, while CASEN used an exceptional, primarily telephone collection design (Cerletti et al., 2024; Ministerio de Desarrollo Social y Familia, 2022). Income, who responded, and how respondents were contacted changed together. No design here separates those margins. The main comparison therefore uses same-year 2011, 2017, and 2024 observations. CASEN 2020 and 2022 describe its own higher-frequency path; they are not mechanical matches or mode corrections for EFH 2021.

The three inferential contrasts emphasized below are the 2017–2021 EFH income fall, the 2021–2024 income reversal, and the 2021–2024 wealth increase. The endpoint, component

accounts, survivor-domain exercises, and rank-overlap statistics are descriptive diagnostics. They can narrow interpretations without identifying why the survey systems disagree.

3 Data, estimands, and inference

3.1 EFH waves and primary resources

The main EFH sequence uses the national-urban waves from 2007, 2011, 2014, 2017, 2021, and 2024. The 2008, 2009, and 2010 Greater Santiago surveys are not inserted into the national series. The statistical unit is the household and the weight is the provider’s household expansion factor.

The primary income resource is effective monthly household income excluding imputed owner rent, named `ytothef` in the two earliest files and `ytotef` thereafter. Total income including imputed rent is a sensitivity. The primary wealth resource is signed non-pension net wealth, defined as the provider-consistent asset total less the debt total. Negative values remain negative. Because the 2024 questionnaire adds cryptoassets to the provider total, a modern-common sensitivity removes that category from 2024; a stricter legacy-common basket also removes separately measured account savings from the later waves. A zero-capped Gini is reported only to show the effect of that normalization. Current pension benefits received by household members enter the EFH income aggregate as income flows. The “non-pension” qualification applies only to wealth: accrued mandatory pension entitlements, including AFP balances, cannot be valued consistently from the six released household files and are therefore excluded from the balance-sheet measure. Constructing a comparable pension-wealth measure would require auxiliary records and assumptions that are not available consistently across the six released waves. Macro scaling, Pareto corrections, and a top-one-percent series are also outside scope.

Table 1 summarizes the six-wave analytical sequence. The supplement provides a parallel EFH–CASEN crosswalk with field periods, collection modes, income reference periods, and response rates wherever the released documentation reports them.

Every nonlinear statistic is estimated separately in all 30 completed data sets and pooled with Rubin’s rules. The 2017, 2021, and 2024 intervals use all 1,000 provider replicate weights; the earlier releases lack those weights and use a fixed-seed bootstrap within the released income strata, so their intervals remain qualified. Signed wealth retains negative balance sheets, and bottom-50 and top-10 shares use fractional population boundaries. A change is called robust only when it survives both a covariance-agnostic bound for the two wave estimates and Holm

Wave	Households	Fieldwork and mode	Income reference	Response rate
2007	3,828	Nov. 2007–Jan. 2008; in person	Current monthly; labor last month	n.r.
2011	4,059	Sep. 2011–May 2012; in person	Current monthly; labor last month	n.r.
2014	4,502	Jul. 2014–Feb. 2015; in person	Current monthly; labor last month	n.r.
2017	4,549	20 Jun.–5 Dec. 2017; in person	Current monthly; labor last month	n.r.
2021	4,400	4 Sep. 2021–31 Mar. 2022; precontact in person, interview mainly by telephone	Current monthly; labor last month	n.r.
2024	4,649	22 Jul. 2024–13 Jan. 2025; in person	Current monthly; labor last month	71.5%

Table 1: EFH analytical sequence and fieldwork. “n.r.” means that an overall response rate was not reported in the reviewed wave document; target-attainment rates are not substituted for response rates.

adjustment across the registered adjacent-wave family. Sections 4–9 of the Technical Supplement define the weighted signed Gini, multiple-imputation pooling, rank-overlap measures, CASEN covariance estimator, and income- and wealth-accounting identities; Section 11 reports the synthetic validation exercises.

3.2 CASEN comparison

CASEN rounds from 2011, 2017, 2020, 2022, and 2024 are reduced to one record per household head and restricted to urban households. The resource is corrected monetary household income excluding imputed rent. Estimates use the released expansion factor, pseudo-stratum, and pseudo-PSU fields, together with the 2011 finite-population correction where available ([Ministerio de Desarrollo Social y Familia, 2011–2024](#)). Taylor linearization supplies the main Gini intervals. Deterministic stratified delete-one-PSU jackknife replicates supply uncertainty for the nonlinear component statistics.

The direct EFH and CASEN comparison remains limited to 2011, 2017, and 2024. These align survey year, urban scope, household unit, and the exclusion of imputed rent. The income questionnaires and correction procedures are still not identical. Difference intervals treat the surveys as independent and do not include a model for the residual concept or fieldwork gap.

3.3 What harmonization removes, and what it leaves behind

The comparison removes four transparent differences: rural coverage, repeated person records for a household resource, imputed owner rent, and unmatched survey years. It does not harmonize how income is elicited or corrected. EFH is organized around household finances and balance sheets, whereas CASEN is organized around poverty, labor, social policy, and living conditions. The respondent, recall period, question order, item nonresponse, top-income coverage, and editing rules can therefore remain different after the final columns have similar labels.

The resulting gap is a difference between two released survey estimands, not a decomposition of survey bias. Separating sampling, questionnaire, response, correction, and mode would require a bridge study that asks both modules of a common household sample or links both surveys to a shared administrative outcome. Here the useful standard is to align what can be aligned, quantify uncertainty from each design, and name the differences that remain.

3.4 Income- and wealth-component accounting

I apply the standard Gini decomposition by income source and then use an exact symmetric decomposition to divide changes in each contribution into income-share and concentration terms (Lerman and Yitzhaki, 1985; Shorrocks, 1982). For EFH in 2014, 2017, 2021, and 2024, total effective income is divided into labor income y_{labh} , public transfers y_{subh} , and other autonomous income $y_{penh} + y_{otroh}$. For CASEN, corrected monetary income is divided into corrected labor income, monetary transfers, and corrected autonomous income less labor income. The derived CASEN transfer component ensures exact add-up; its difference from the released direct subsidy field is 1 or 2 CLP in most rounds and 3 CLP for a negligible share of the revised 2020 file. The discrepancy is retained in the validation record.

Let s_{kt} denote component k 's share of mean total income and C_{kt} its concentration coefficient when households are ranked by total income. Tied totals receive a common weighted midrank. The total Gini is

$$G_t = \sum_k s_{kt} C_{kt}.$$

The change in each component's contribution is divided symmetrically:

$$\Delta(s_k C_k) = \frac{1}{2} \Delta s_k (C_{kt} + C_{k0}) + \frac{1}{2} \Delta C_k (s_{kt} + s_{k0}).$$

The first term is called the share effect and the second the concentration effect. These are accounting terms, not behavioral or causal effects.

The same identity is used for a bounded wealth account over 2021–2024, the two waves that share both provider replicate weights and a stable component mapping. Signed non-pension net wealth is divided into principal residence, other real estate, vehicles and other real assets, financial and transaction-account assets, and debt entered as a negative component. Households are ranked by total signed net wealth. Company participations remain inside financial assets and business machinery inside other real assets because the released aggregates do not support a comparable stand-alone business component in both waves.

3.5 Survivor domain and disclosure safeguards

The released 2024 household key links exactly 1,801 reinterviewed households to the 2021 refresh cohort. For this domain, both years first use the 2024 final weight and all 1,000 2024 provider replicates; the exercise is then repeated with common 2021 weights and replicates. Each year’s 30 implicates are estimated separately. The cross-wave imputations were not jointly drawn, so changes again use the covariance-agnostic bound. Baseline income, wealth, household size, macrozone, and stratum composition are compared with the 1,054 households in the 2021 refresh cohort that were not reinterviewed, using 2021 weights.

The linkage produces aggregate estimates only. Household keys and trajectories never enter the outputs, nor do unweighted or small-support cells. The module also checks the linkage, common weights, replicate alignment, and disclosure rules before reporting a survivor-domain result.

The validated samples contain 3,828, 4,059, 4,502, 4,549, 4,400, and 4,649 households in the six national-urban waves, respectively. All waves contain 30 implicates, have exactly zero completed-data weighted missingness for primary effective income and net wealth, and pass the prespecified income-accounting tolerance. The 2017, 2021, and 2024 intervals use the provider’s 1,000 replicate weights; earlier-wave intervals remain qualified approximations.

4 The EFH path across income and wealth

Before turning to the cross-survey comparison, Figure 1, introduced in the opening section, establishes the path measured within EFH across two household resources. Does EFH show

continuing income compression into 2024, and do the recent income and non-pension net-wealth measures move in the same direction? The first panel shows modest income-Gini compression between 2007 and 2017, an exceptional trough in 2021, and a return to approximately the 2017 value in 2024. The second shows high signed non-pension wealth inequality throughout and a sharp increase between 2021 and 2024.

4.1 Income: an exceptional trough and rebound

The household effective-income Gini declines from 0.553 in 2007 to 0.519 in 2017, then falls to 0.439 in 2021 and returns to 0.523 in 2024. Across the full period, the 2024 EFH household effective-income Gini is 0.030 below the 2007 point estimate. Its conservative 95% interval, $[-0.076, 0.016]$, ranges from a larger decline to a small increase. The endpoint comparison therefore suggests modest compression but does not precisely establish its size. Formal adjacent-wave tests concentrate the statistically resolved movement around 2021. After Holm adjustment and under the widest feasible cross-wave intervals, only 3 of the ten Gini changes remain distinguishable from zero. Two of those changes define the income path: the Gini fell by 0.079 from 2017 to 2021 and rose by 0.084 from 2021 to 2024. The third is the 2021–2024 wealth increase discussed below. None of the earlier adjacent changes remains distinguishable from zero under the same standard. EFH therefore supports an exceptional income compression followed by a rebound, rather than a sequence of statistically resolved declines across the six waves. These estimates compare repeated cross sections and carry no causal interpretation.

The six-wave shape is more informative than either endpoint alone. Compression before the pandemic is modest beside the 2021 drop, and the 2024 estimate closes almost the entire gap with 2017. EFH therefore records some long-run income compression, but its recent path is an exceptional trough followed by a rebound, not a continuing decline into 2024. Technical Supplement Tables S1 and S2 report the full levels, distributional shares, and adjacent-wave contrasts.

The bottom-half and top-decile income shares locate the same three phases in the distribution. From 2007 to 2017, the top-10 share falls by 5.4 percentage points while the bottom-50 share rises by 0.7 points, consistent with modest compression driven more visibly at the top. The exceptional 2021 observation then moves both tails sharply toward equality: relative to 2017, the bottom half gains 4.9 points and the top decile loses 6.5. Those movements almost fully reverse by 2024. The Gini path is therefore supported by familiar tail shares rather than by one

summary index alone.

4.2 Wealth: does it follow the recent income path?

Income describes households' current command over resources, but it does not show whether their accumulated economic position became less concentrated. The second panel of Figure 1 therefore turns to wealth, a stock of housing, businesses, financial assets, durable goods, and debt. Across the first five EFH waves, the wealth Gini fluctuates without a statistically significant adjacent change under the paper's conservative inference procedure. It then moves from 0.698 in 2021 to 0.766 in 2024, its highest point estimate in the six-wave sequence. This final increase remains distinguishable from zero after the same covariance and multiplicity adjustments.

The wealth shares also place the change at both ends of the distribution. Between 2021 and 2024, the bottom half's share of signed net wealth falls by 4.4 percentage points and the top decile's share rises by 6.0 points. The wealth-Gini increase is therefore not an isolated response of that index.

An exact component account locates the point increase across several broad parts of the balance sheet. The five components reproduce the signed wealth Gini exactly in both waves. At the point estimates, other real estate makes the largest contribution to the 2021–2024 increase (0.044 of the 0.068 Gini-point change). Financial and transaction-account assets also contribute positively, while the debt contribution becomes less negative, so debt offsets measured concentration less strongly in 2024. Each component-specific covariance-agnostic interval includes zero, so the account describes where the point change appears rather than identifying a single statistically resolved driver. Technical Supplement Table S6 reports the complete account, including the offsetting movement in principal-residence wealth and component-specific uncertainty.

The result also survives alternative treatments of the tails. The wealth-Gini increase remains when negative balances are set to zero, while the income and wealth movements retain their direction when each wave is capped at its weighted p99 or p99.5. These thresholds are recomputed in every implicate and replicate; Technical Supplement Table S4 reports them as influence checks rather than replacements for the uncapped distributions.

The increase is also robust to holding the measured asset scope more nearly constant. Removing the crypto category introduced in 2024 leaves the 2021–2024 Gini change at 0.0680, with a conservative interval of [0.0325, 0.1034]. Under the stricter legacy-common basket, which

additionally removes separately measured account savings in both waves, the change is 0.0667 [0.0311, 0.1023]. Technical Supplement Table S5 reports these constructions together with their upper-tail checks.

The wealth result remains bounded by the released survey concept. Signed wealth keeps liabilities that exceed included assets, so its bottom-50 share can be negative; setting those balances to zero changes both the resource and the Gini's normalization. Pension wealth, macro-balance-sheet scaling, and a corrected extreme upper tail could change the level and interpretation. Those extensions belong to the broader wealth concept studied by [Castro Nofal et al. \(2026\)](#), and a top-one-percent estimate would be too dependent on a few highly weighted EFH observations to support here.

Taken together, the two panels answer whether EFH-measured income and non-pension net-wealth inequality moved in the same direction between the two most recent waves. From 2021 to 2024, both Ginis increase, both top-decile shares rise, and both bottom-half shares fall. The exceptional income compression observed in 2021 had disappeared by 2024, while non-pension net-wealth inequality also rose. Their parallel movement broadens the evidence that both current income flows and accumulated non-pension net wealth became more concentrated among upper-ranked urban households, without implying that the changes arose from a common mechanism.

4.3 How closely do income and wealth rank the same households?

The value of observing both resources in EFH extends beyond comparing two aggregate Ginis. Income and wealth capture related but distinct dimensions of economic position. Income measures the flow of resources available over a period, whereas wealth records accumulated assets net of liabilities and can provide economic security, finance large investments, support borrowing, and transmit advantage across generations. Age, homeownership, debt, inheritance, and past saving can therefore place households with similar current incomes at very different points in the wealth distribution. International joint-distribution research accordingly finds that income and wealth are only partially correlated, with closer alignment near the tails than around the middle ([Balestra and Oehler, 2023](#)). Chilean evidence from the 2014 EFH likewise describes a weak cross-sectional relationship between income and wealth position ([Martínez and Uribe, 2018](#)). Table 2 asks whether the six national waves preserve that pattern.

Across the six national waves, weighted household income–wealth rank correlations range from

Wave	Income-wealth Spearman	Bottom-20% overlap	Top-20% overlap	Top-10% overlap
2007	0.202 [0.162, 0.241]	0.185 [0.150, 0.220]	0.440 [0.407, 0.473]	0.421 [0.386, 0.456]
2011	0.262 [0.230, 0.295]	0.198 [0.166, 0.229]	0.477 [0.449, 0.505]	0.429 [0.393, 0.466]
2014	0.288 [0.247, 0.330]	0.247 [0.205, 0.290]	0.481 [0.442, 0.521]	0.391 [0.337, 0.444]
2017	0.288 [0.254, 0.322]	0.263 [0.229, 0.297]	0.465 [0.432, 0.499]	0.459 [0.418, 0.500]
2021	0.288 [0.246, 0.331]	0.266 [0.225, 0.307]	0.502 [0.463, 0.541]	0.456 [0.410, 0.502]
2024	0.262 [0.219, 0.306]	0.253 [0.213, 0.292]	0.466 [0.429, 0.504]	0.418 [0.368, 0.468]

Table 2: The joint distribution of EFH household income and wealth

Entries are weighted point estimates with 95 percent intervals, pooled over all 30 implicates. The first column is weighted Spearman rank correlation. Each overlap is the probability of occupying the stated wealth tail conditional on occupying the same income tail. The independence benchmarks are 0.20 for quintiles and 0.10 for the top decile. These are repeated cross-sectional associations, not measures of household mobility.

0.202 to 0.288. Conditional overlap ranges from 0.440 to 0.502 for the top quintile, 0.185 to 0.266 for the bottom quintile, and 0.391 to 0.459 for the top decile. The top-quintile and top-decile point estimates exceed their respective independence benchmarks in every wave. Bottom-quintile overlap is near its 0.20 benchmark in 2007 and 2011 and modestly above it thereafter. The estimates describe repeated cross sections and do not measure mobility of particular households.

The tail measures reveal an important asymmetry: income and wealth identify many of the same high-resource households, particularly within the narrow top decile, but much less consistently identify the same households at the bottom. The parallel 2021–2024 increases indicate greater concentration across two related dimensions of economic position rather than duplicate measurements of an unchanged household ranking. The repeated cross sections cannot establish that the increases share a cause.

5 Characterizing the post-2017 disagreement

5.1 The closest income comparison

Figure 4 brings the paper’s central comparison into view. It places the three same-year EFH comparisons beside the two intermediate CASEN rounds. CASEN rises from 0.482 in 2017 to 0.518 in the 2020 pandemic round, then falls to 0.473 in 2022 and 0.464 in 2024. EFH instead records its trough in 2021 and is back at 0.523 in 2024. The two surveys thus agree that the pandemic period was unusual but disagree about the path from 2017 to the latest common year.

At all three common survey years, EFH reports the higher income Gini. The gap narrows slightly between 2011 and 2017 before reaching its widest value in 2024; all three gaps remain distinguishable from zero after Holm adjustment within the Gini comparisons. The intervals account for each survey’s sampling uncertainty, including the CASEN complex design and EFH

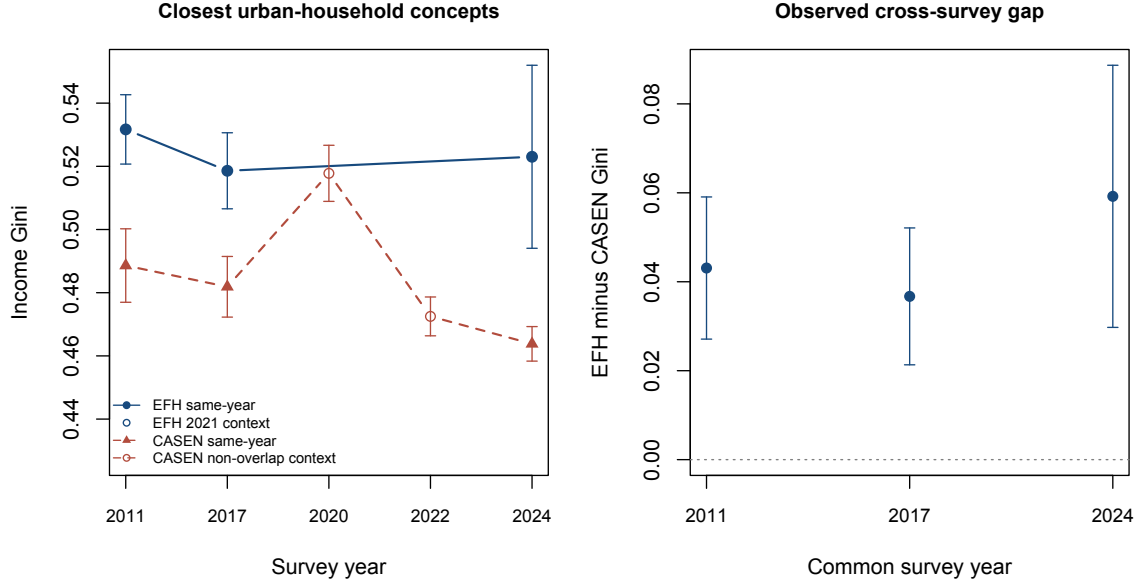


Figure 4: Closest-concept EFH and CASEN income inequality

multiple imputation, but they do not capture residual differences in questionnaires, fieldwork, nonresponse, or income construction and therefore cannot assign the gap to either survey.

Table 3 makes the recent comparison explicit. CASEN’s 2017–2024 decline is distinguishable from zero under the independent-wave calculation, whereas EFH’s small increase is not. The difference between those changes is positive, but its interval includes zero under either variance convention. Thus the evidence establishes different point-estimate paths and a widening level gap, rather than a statistically resolved difference in trends. The same directional contrast appears when income is assigned to represented persons or imputed rent is included, though these two conventions are post-analysis descriptive checks.

Convention	EFH	CASEN	Difference in changes
Households, excluding rent	0.004	-0.018	0.022 [-0.011, 0.056]
Represented persons, excluding rent	0.001	-0.019	0.020 [-0.012, 0.053]
Households, including rent	-0.003	-0.022	0.018 [-0.014, 0.050]

Table 3: Income-Gini changes from 2017 to 2024 under alternative conventions

Entries are 2024 minus 2017 Gini changes. The final column reports the EFH change minus the CASEN change with an independent-survey 95 percent interval. Represented-person and including-rent results are post-analysis descriptive checks and do not enter the primary hypothesis family.

The Gini comparison is not an artifact of that index alone. The tail shares tell the same directional story as the Ginis. From 2017 to 2024, EFH’s bottom-50 income share changes by -0.001 and its top-10 share by 0.003, whereas CASEN’s corresponding changes are 0.008 and -0.021. CASEN therefore records compression at both ends—a larger share for the bottom

half and a smaller share for the top decile—while EFH records little endpoint movement in the opposite direction. In absolute terms, the cross-survey difference in changes is larger for the top-10 share (0.024) than for the bottom-50 share (-0.008), so the point-estimate disagreement is visible at both tails but more pronounced at the top. Neither difference in changes is statistically conclusive under the independent-wave intervals reported in the Technical Supplement’s full tail-share table. The share measures are especially useful here because their direction is easy to interpret: compression gives the bottom half more income and the top decile less. They do not identify what happened within either group, but they show which broad parts of the distribution accompany the Gini paths.

The observed gap is not a decomposition of survey bias. The 2024 EFH estimate has wider uncertainty than CASEN because its sample is smaller and its multiple-imputation and replicate variation are material. Even after sampling uncertainty is included, however, the cross-survey gap is positive in all three common years. Section 5.4 considers the remaining survey differences and why the present data cannot identify their separate effects.

5.2 What changed inside household income?

Figure 5 reports each component’s exact contribution to the total-income Gini. The EFH decomposition clarifies both sides of the 2021 episode: labor and other-autonomous contributions contract as transfers take a much larger share of measured income, then those movements largely reverse by 2024. Transfer receipts also become less concentrated among households ranked near the bottom of total income, which offsets part of the equalizing share shift.

Public transfers’ share of measured EFH effective income rose from 0.8% of EFH effective income in 2017 to 13.5% in 2021, then fell to 3.1% in 2024. The 2017 to 2021 income-Gini decline is accounted for by contribution changes of -0.050 for labor income, -0.039 for other autonomous income, and 0.009 for transfers. Transfers’ larger share of measured income displaced more concentrated income shares, while transfer receipts became less concentrated among households ranked near the bottom of total income, offsetting part of that compression. CASEN follows a different pandemic sequence: its income Gini rises in 2020, falls sharply by 2022, and edges down again by 2024. Component contributions are exact descriptive accounts and do not identify transfer effects.

The exact decomposition helps avoid a common misreading of transfer income. A component can reduce the total Gini through two distinct margins. Its share of mean income may rise while

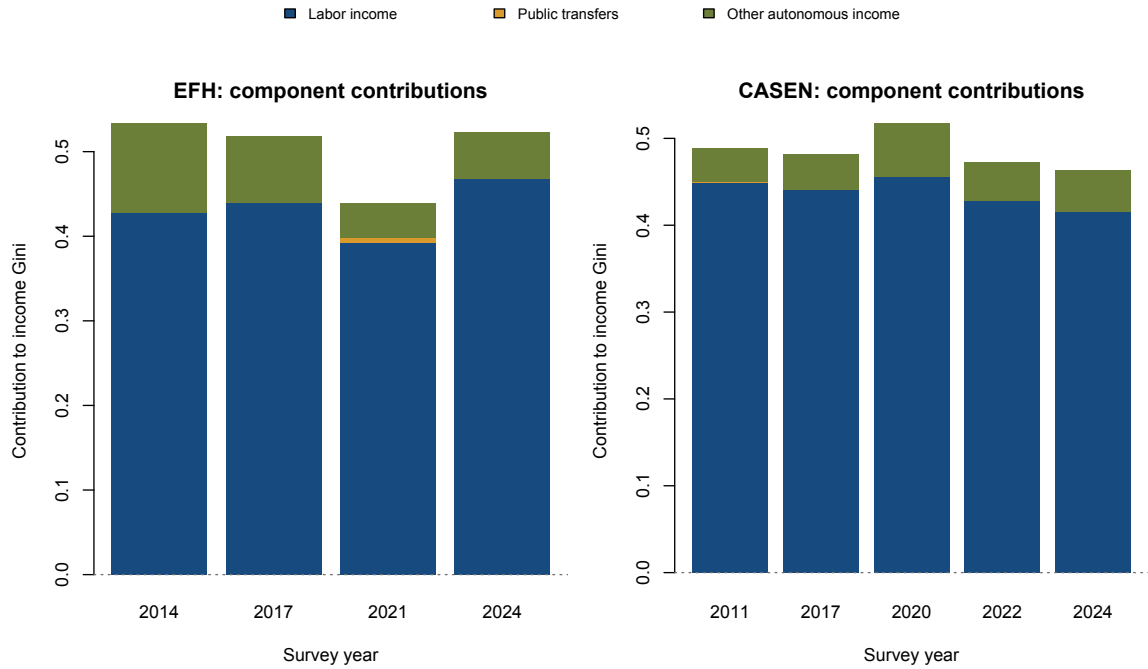


Figure 5: Income-component contributions to the Gini

more concentrated components lose share, and its own concentration coefficient may be low or negative because it is received disproportionately by households below the total-income mean. These margins need not point in the same direction. In the 2021 EFH, transfers account for a much larger part of mean income, yet their positive contribution partly offsets rather than mechanically explains the entire compression. Most of the fall is recorded in the smaller labor and other-autonomous contributions.

Even this exactness has a narrow meaning. A smaller labor contribution can reflect lower labor's mean share, less dispersion in labor income, reranking when transfers are included in total income, or all three. It does not by itself show that labor-income inequality fell. Likewise, a negative CASEN transfer contribution says that transfer receipts are concentrated toward lower total-income ranks; it does not estimate the Gini that would prevail if the transfer system were removed and households did not change behavior.

CASEN tells a different component story. Its Gini rises in 2020 because the labor and other-autonomous contributions increase more than the transfer contribution becomes negative. By 2022 the labor contribution falls sharply, and it declines again by 2024. The difference matters for interpretation: the two surveys do not merely attach different levels to a common turning point. They record different timing and different component contributions.

The common endpoint sharpens that contrast. Labor income adds 0.031 to the EFH Gini

between 2017 and 2024 but subtracts 0.021 from the CASEN Gini. Other autonomous income partly offsets the difference, while transfers contribute about -0.004 in each survey. The new covariance-agnostic component intervals, reported in the supplement, are wide enough to caution against treating any one component as an isolated mechanism. The account identifies where the two observed changes reside; it cannot say whether the labor contrast reflects economic coverage, reporting, correction, or sample composition.

The decomposition is deliberately silent about statistical significance for individual mechanisms. It reports shares, concentration coefficients, and exact contributions with source-specific uncertainty, but it does not search across component-level hypotheses. The key conclusion is narrower. The EFH 2021 compression coincides with a temporary income composition that is absent by 2024, while CASEN’s higher-frequency path places its pandemic peak in 2020 and its decline thereafter.

The timing difference also disciplines the interpretation of survey mode. Both surveys had unusual pandemic collection, yet the highest recent CASEN Gini is in 2020 while the lowest recent EFH Gini is in 2021. Telephone collection alone therefore cannot explain the direction of both patterns without a model of who responded, what was asked, and the economic conditions at each field date. The intermediate CASEN rounds are therefore valuable as a description of its own path, not as a mode correction to EFH.

5.3 The survivor-domain check

The repeated-cross-section movements could reflect who entered the 2024 refresh sample. Table 4 tests whether that explanation is sufficient by holding the linked household set fixed and applying a common weighting system to both years.

Resource	Domain and weights	2021 Gini	2024 Gini	Change
Effective income	Repeated cross-section	0.439 [0.427, 0.451]	0.523 [0.494, 0.552]	0.084 [0.043, 0.125]
Effective income	Survivors, common 2024 weights	0.444 [0.425, 0.462]	0.528 [0.469, 0.587]	0.084 [0.007, 0.162]
Effective income	Survivors, common 2021 weights	0.440 [0.422, 0.458]	0.536 [0.480, 0.591]	0.096 [0.022, 0.170]
Signed non-pension wealth	Repeated cross-section	0.698 [0.682, 0.715]	0.766 [0.747, 0.785]	0.068 [0.033, 0.103]
Signed non-pension wealth	Survivors, common 2024 weights	0.711 [0.684, 0.738]	0.747 [0.722, 0.771]	0.036 [-0.015, 0.088]
Signed non-pension wealth	Survivors, common 2021 weights	0.709 [0.680, 0.738]	0.741 [0.716, 0.766]	0.032 [-0.022, 0.086]

Table 4: Repeated cross-section and survivor-domain income and wealth Ginis

Each survivor row uses the stated year’s final weight and all 1,000 corresponding provider replicates for both years. Change intervals use the covariance-agnostic Cauchy bound because cross-wave imputations were not jointly drawn. Wealth tail shares also move toward greater concentration under both common-weight systems, but their conservative change intervals include zero. This is a 2024 survivor domain, not a population panel.

Among the 1,801 households reinterviewed in 2024, the common-weight income Gini rose from 0.444 to 0.528, a change of 0.084 [0.007, 0.162]. With common 2021 weights the corresponding change is 0.096 [0.022, 0.170]. The survivor-domain reversal means that refresh-sample composition is not sufficient to account for the repeated-cross-section income result. Signed non-pension wealth also moves toward greater concentration among the same households. Under common 2024 weights, its Gini rises from 0.711 to 0.747, a change of 0.036 [-0.015, 0.088]; the common-2021-weight change is 0.032 [-0.022, 0.086]. Under both weighting systems the wealth top-10 share rises and the bottom-50 share falls, although all three conservative wealth-change intervals include zero. The wealth direction therefore survives the composition check, but the survivor-domain evidence is attenuated relative to the repeated cross section and is not statistically resolved. This domain is not a population panel: survival, nonresponse, and separately drawn cross-wave imputations limit its interpretation.

The attrition diagnostic is reassuring but not dispositive. Using 2021 weights, survivors and the non-reinterviewed remainder of the 2021 refresh cohort have similar average baseline income, wealth, household size, macrozone shares, and income-stratum shares. The standardized differences for income, wealth, and household size are 0.00, 0.04, and 0.09 in absolute value. That comparison cannot rule out selection on unobserved outcomes or future changes, but it supports the limited inference that refresh composition by itself does not generate the reversal. The full continuous and categorical balance table appears in the supplement.

5.4 What the diagnostics leave unresolved

The component and survivor exercises narrow the space of explanations but do not partition the EFH–CASEN gap. The direct comparison fixes the survey year, urban population, household unit, and treatment of imputed rent, so those choices do not explain the 2024 disagreement.

Several remaining margins could matter for the recorded distribution. The surveys’ purposes, respondent selection, recall periods, and question order can affect which income sources are recalled and reported. Their procedures for item nonresponse, editing, imputation, and income correction can alter the recorded mass in different parts of the distribution. EFH’s wealth-related oversampling and smaller sample may affect precision and which high-resource households enter the sample, while differential nonresponse can remain after weighting. Fieldwork timing and mode can likewise affect both who responds and the economic circumstances to which their answers refer.

These features differ jointly rather than one at a time. The observed gap therefore cannot identify the contribution of any single feature or establish that either survey is biased. Attributing the remainder would require a bridge survey that administered both income modules to the same sampled households or linked both surveys to a common administrative benchmark.

6 Discussion and conclusion

What does the evidence show about Chile’s inequality trajectory since the return to democracy? For income, the historical CASEN record establishes a substantial decline: it places income inequality well below its 1990s level by the middle of the 2010s, and several international databases reproduce that decline after applying different methods to CASEN. Because EFH begins only in 2007, it cannot adjudicate the earlier fall. What it can show is how far that conclusion travels into the 2020s, across survey systems, and from income to wealth.

For recent income inequality, the two survey systems do not yield a single answer. CASEN’s closest income Gini falls between 2017 and 2024. EFH’s income Gini instead reaches an exceptional trough in 2021 and returns to approximately its 2017 level by 2024; over its full 2007–2024 span, the endpoint is consistent with either modest net compression or little net movement. Assigning income to represented persons or including imputed rent preserves this directional contrast, and the EFH-minus-CASEN gap grows. The interval for the difference between the 2017–2024 changes includes zero, so the paper establishes different observed paths and growing disagreement rather than a statistically resolved ranking of survey trends. Bottom-half and top-decile income shares reinforce that interpretation. CASEN records compression at both tails from 2017 to 2024, whereas EFH records little endpoint movement in the opposite direction; the point-estimate difference is larger at the top of the distribution.

The component and survivor exercises help characterize that disagreement without purporting to resolve it. EFH’s 2021 trough occurs when public transfers take a much larger share of measured income and the labor and other-autonomous contributions contract; by 2024, that composition has largely receded. The income rebound also remains among the 1,801 reinterviewed households under either common weighting system, while the observed baseline diagnostics show limited differences between survivors and the remaining 2021 refresh sample. Refresh-sample composition is therefore not a sufficient explanation. Economic change, attrition, questionnaire design, nonresponse, fieldwork mode, and within-household measurement remain intertwined, and the

analysis cannot assign the residual disagreement to any one of them.

For wealth inequality, EFH does not show a sustained decline across the full six-wave sequence. The wealth Gini fluctuates without a statistically significant adjacent change across the first five waves; between 2021 and 2024, however, it rises sharply. The top-decile share rises and the bottom-half share falls as well, while EFH income inequality moves in the same direction. The wealth increase persists when negative balances are set to zero, the upper tail is capped, and the measured asset scope is held more nearly constant. The same direction remains among reinterviewed households under either common weighting system, though the survivor-domain change is smaller and its interval includes zero. An exact decomposition places the largest point contribution in other real estate, with financial assets also contributing positively and debt offsetting measured concentration less strongly in 2024; no individual component change is statistically resolved under the conservative bounds. Its interpretation remains bounded: the primary measure excludes mandatory pension entitlements, macro scaling, and a corrected extreme upper tail. Within that scope, the wealth evidence does not extend a story of continuing compression through 2024. Household income and wealth ranks are positively but imperfectly associated across all six waves, so the parallel final-wave increases concern related dimensions of economic position rather than duplicate measures of the same resource. Conditional tail overlap is much stronger at the top than at the bottom: the joint concentration of income and wealth is most apparent among high-resource households.

The joint-distribution results matter because income and wealth do not identify the same households equally well across the distribution. Their strong overlap at the top shows that high income and high wealth frequently coincide, whereas the much weaker overlap at the bottom distinguishes low current income from limited accumulated resources. Earnings, cash transfers, and labor taxation can alter current income relatively quickly, whereas housing values, debt, saving, capital taxation, and inheritances reshape household balance sheets cumulatively. Policies aimed at current income and household balance sheets may therefore reach different households, while policies that affect both resources may do so with different intensity and timing. The parallel 2021–2024 increases broaden the evidence of greater concentration, but the EFH data do not establish that they share a cause or identify the policies behind them.

The scope of these conclusions is deliberately bounded. First, EFH represents urban households, and the harmonized CASEN comparison excludes rural households; the results therefore do not describe Chile’s rural distribution. Second, the main estimates are repeated cross sections,

while the survivor exercise describes a restricted domain rather than a representative population panel. Third, neither survey supplies an external benchmark for the unobserved true income distribution, and the design cannot attribute either the EFH–CASEN difference or the parallel income and wealth movements to a particular mechanism. Fourth, neither income series corrects for households missing from the extreme upper tail. Combining household-survey evidence with tax records and national accounts, [Flores et al. \(2020\)](#) recover a U-shaped post-democracy income path that differs from the conventional survey-only decline. That result does not adjudicate the EFH–CASEN comparison, but it shows that both survey systems describe a narrower object than a top-adjusted income distribution. Finally, EFH is purpose-built for household finances and uses wealth-related oversampling and multiple imputation, but it remains a survey measure. The wealth estimates exclude mandatory pension entitlements, are not reconciled to national balance sheets, and do not correct for households missing from the extreme upper tail. The upper-tail sensitivities show that the reported increase is not driven solely by the largest observed values; they cannot recover wealth held by households the survey does not observe. A broader construction that integrates EFH with administrative pension records, national balance sheets, and top-tail corrections finds that these additions materially change the level and composition of measured Chilean wealth while retaining a modest decline through 2021 ([Castro Nofal et al., 2026](#)). That is a different estimand rather than a corrected version of the released EFH measure used here.

Taken together, the results show why the period, household resource, statistical unit, construction method, and underlying microdata belong in any assessment of Chile’s inequality trajectory. Even after the closest EFH–CASEN comparison aligns year, urban coverage, household unit, and imputed rent, the recent paths remain different and the available data cannot identify which residual survey feature produces the gap. Source lineage must therefore enter substantive inference: agreement among CASEN descendants demonstrates robustness across treatments of common microdata, not independent replication across survey systems. Chile’s historical income compression remains well supported, but the evidence does not support carrying it forward as an unconditional story of continuing decline. Whether measured inequality continued to fall through 2024 depends on both the survey system and the household resource under study.

Declarations

Data and code availability

EFH microdata are restricted and are not redistributed. Researchers must obtain them from Banco Central de Chile and comply with the provider’s terms. CASEN inputs are frozen official public releases with checksums and retrieval metadata. The repository contains reproducible estimators, symbolic and numerical checks, Monte Carlo validation, output contracts, and a fail-closed build, and is available on [GitHub](#). It is not a self-contained public replication package because the EFH microdata and unrestricted dissemination rights are not included.

Conflicts of interest

The author reports no conflict of interest.

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